WORKING PAPER

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Working conditions and sustainable work

Managing challenges in hybrid work: Auxilia (France)

[Report that the paper supports]

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This report presents the results of research conducted prior to the outbreak of COVID-19 in Europe in February 2020. For this reason, the results do not take account of the outbreak.

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Contents

Table of contents

Introduction **4**
Background and objectives 4
Methodological approach 4
Reason for selecting this particular case 5
Structure of the report 5
1 – Organisation profile and contextual information **1**
Organisation characteristics 1
National context 2
Pre-COVID-19 hybrid work practice 3
2 – Description of the hybrid work model **5**
Post-COVID-19 hybrid work model 5
Tools and technologies used 6
Future of the hybrid work model 6
3 – Organisational outcomes **8**
Efficiency and workflow changes 8
Communication and collaboration dynamics 8
Company culture and team cohesion 9
4 – Organisational and management challenges **11**
Digital infrastructure and communication tools 11
Office space and on-site work environment 12
Remote work settings 13
5 - Managerial practices and strategies **16**
Challenges and changes in roles and leadership style of line managers 16
Management of well-being in the hybrid work model 16
Impact of hybrid work on management practices 16
Supporting managers in a hybrid work model 19
Recommendations for managers 20
6 – Lessons learned and key takeaways **22**
References **24**
Annex I **1**
Annex II **1**

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Introduction

Background and objectives

This working paper presents the case study of Auxilia, a French association headquartered in Paris supporting local authorities and businesses in their green transition, which had adopted hybrid work practices even before the COVID-19 pandemic. The case study illustrates a flexible hybrid model, characterised by significant employee autonomy over work location and scheduling. Employees work from home, client sites, or the employer's premises, reflecting the organisation's project-based and travel-intensive activities. For most roles, remote work constitutes a substantial proportion of working time, with no mandatory office attendance requirements. Employees determine their working hours autonomously within broad organisational parameters and may adjust their remote working patterns from week to week without prior approval. A formal charter signed in 2021 defines procedural aspects of remote work but largely formalises pre-existing practices and does not impose fixed schedules or mandatory on-site days. Employees can adjust their remote working patterns from week to week without prior approval. While some roles require continuous on-site presence, the overall model reflects high flexibility and trust-based management consistent with a fully flexible hybrid arrangement.

This case study starts with a description of the specific hybrid work model, and then it examines how various stakeholders interviewed perceive the management challenges associated with hybrid work and whether specific practices or tools have been introduced to address them. It also examines how internal dialogue and organisational adaptation contribute to the implementation and sustainability of the hybrid work model.

Methodological approach

The research began with an exploratory interview with the company's director to clarify the study's objectives and facilitate access to internal documents, such as employment contracts and the remote work charter [Charte sur le télétravail]. Following this, a series of semi-structured interviews was carried out using a predefined questionnaire, which was organised around key thematic areas and tailored to different types of interviewees, ensuring both consistency and relevance. In total, five individual interviews were conducted with the director, two staff representatives, a line manager, and a human resource manager. Each interview was held separately during the fieldwork conducted between June and July 2025, providing in-depth insights into individual experiences and practices.

Four of the stakeholders interviewed are located in Paris, and the fifth works and resides in Nantes. Their respective job positions and departments are listed in Table 1. Participants were chosen by the director. All interviews were conducted online via video calls and lasted approximately one hour. Prior to each interview, informed consent for recording was obtained, and participants were provided with the data protection notice. The interviews were subsequently transcribed and analysed using thematic analysis to identify key patterns and themes.

Table 1: List of conducted interviews with the company representatives

Interviewee type	Job position & department	Date
Line Manager 1	General Director	10/07/2025

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HR Representative	HR Director, HR department	26/06/2025
Employee representative 1 (works council)	Employee representative, project manager, green transition department	24/06/2025
Employee representative 2 (works council)	Employee representative, consultant, green transition department	4/07/2025
Line Manager 2	Manager, As the deputy chief executive officer of territorial development department	21/07/2025

Reason for selecting this particular case

Auxilia was selected as a case study due to several factors that render its hybrid work practices particularly relevant. As a non-profit organisation providing consulting services, it operates in a sector where travelling to meet clients is essential, making hybrid work arrangements necessary. Additionally, Auxilia adopted the hybrid work model before the COVID-19 pandemic. Changes prior to and after the global shift to remote work can therefore be studied. Lastly, this case shows a discrepancy between the company's formal policies, as stated in employees' contracts, and its day-to-day practice. This difference between the formally defined, contractual, Controlled hybrid model and the informally practised model provides insights into the challenges of operationalising hybrid work and highlights how gradual, practice-driven adaptations can shape organisational outcomes.

Structure of the report

The structure of this working paper closely follows the interview guidelines developed for the study.

Chapter 1, **Organisation profile and contextual information**, provides key details about the chosen company's structure and operations, followed by an overview of the national context relevant to hybrid workplaces.

Chapter 2, **Description of the hybrid work model**, offers an overview of how the Remote-Friendly Hybrid model operates. It summarises the main organisational rules, explains the rationale and process behind its selection and implementation, and discusses future plans.

Chapter 3, **Organisational outcomes**, examines how hybrid work has influenced several key aspects of work organisation. It considers efficiency and workflow adjustments, explores communication and collaboration dynamics, analyses company culture and team cohesion, and offers an overview of how hybrid work reshapes the organisational landscape.

Chapter 4, **Organisational and management challenges**, explores the key organisational and managerial issues stemming from implementing the hybrid work model. It highlights the importance of digital infrastructure and communication tools, and the changing function of office spaces and on-site work environments.

Chapter 5, **Managerial practices and strategies**, offers managerial insights on implementing the hybrid work model, particularly regarding strategies for managing and supporting employee well-being, maintaining team performance, and adapting leadership styles to hybrid environments.

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The report concludes with **lessons learned and key takeaways**, drawn from interview insights that can inform managerial approaches to hybrid work.

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1 – Organisation profile and contextual information

Organisation characteristics

Auxilia is a non-profit organisation, known as an "association" under the French law of 2001. It was established in 2001. As part of the non-profit SOS Group, the company supports local authorities and businesses through their green transition by helping them design and implement sustainable development strategies. Operating under NACE Code 70.22, the organisation works in the field of business and other management consultancy activities. Headquartered in Paris, Auxilia has five other agencies in Lyon, Nantes, Lille, Bordeaux, and Vannes.

As of 2024, Auxilia had around 55 employees. Of these, 27 are located in Paris, 10 in Nantes, 6 in Lyon, and 3 in Bordeaux. However, by 2025, its workforce decreased to 50 employees due to the lack of funds from local authorities. Yet, according to the HR representative interviewed, as of August 2025, the company has around 46 employees and 7 interns.

As of 31 August 2025, the workforce was distributed as follows: 83% of employees (N = 45) were on permanent contracts, 4% (N=2) were on fixed-term contracts, corresponding to two researchers employed on three-year "CIFRE"[1] contracts enabling them to complete their doctoral theses while working part-time for Auxilia, and 13% (N=7) were interns. In terms of gender representation, 52% of the current staff are women (N=28). Auxilia offers three primary types of employment contracts. There is one for administrative staff - a permanent employment contract subject to a collective working schedule, and two for consultants. One is a permanent employment contract based on a fixed number of hours (fixed hourly rate / forfait en heures) for junior consultants, and the other a permanent employment contract based on a fixed number of days (annual working days system / forfait jours) for senior consultants and managers. This distinction is provided for in the collective agreement applicable to Auxilia (Syntec collective agreement), which reserves fixed-day contracts for consultants or managers with remuneration exceeding €3,275[2], with all others remaining on fixed-hour contracts.

Contracts that specify working time in hours (weekly or monthly) are possible for employees. In these cases, working hours are set through individual employment contracts but must comply with the applicable collective agreement. By contrast, forfait-jours (day-based) contracts must be authorised by either a company-level collective agreement or a sectoral (branch) agreement. The number of days under a forfait-jours contract is limited to 218 per year. According to the French Labour Code (Code du Travail), administrative staff are not eligible for contracts based on a fixed number of hours or days, as they are not considered to have sufficient autonomy in the organisation of their work (French Labour Code, 2016). These types of contracts are given to managers who

[1] CIFRE stands for *Industrial Agreements for Training through Research*. The scheme enables companies to employ a doctoral candidate while the research is carried out in partnership with a laboratory. The project forms the basis of the candidate's doctoral thesis and leads to a thesis defence. The company receives a subsidy under legislation introduced in 1981.

[2] Convention collective Syntec, Salaires minimaux des « ingénieurs et cadres », 2025.

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require autonomy in their work schedule or employees whose working hours cannot be predetermined.

Auxilia operates with a relatively centralised management structure. According to the Director, the organisation is composed of ten areas of expertise, each divided into two teams with varying hierarchy levels. The hierarchical structure comprises four levels: 'consultants' (junior and senior), who report to 'project managers', who in turn report to project directors. Each project director is responsible for one or more areas of expertise within the group. While managers have a high level of autonomy, efforts to flatten the hierarchy did not have successful results. Employees often shared that vertical management structures complicated consultancy work and increased their workloads. The organisation is headed by a senior management team comprising the chief executive, two deputy chief executives, and the chief operating officer of Auxilia.

National context

The first legal framework in France regarding remote work was established in 2005 through a national interprofessional agreement (known as the Accord National Interprofessional, ANI). This agreement was concluded as part of the implementation of the 2002 European Framework Agreement on Telework, signed at the EU level by social partners. In France, the ANI of 19 July 2005 was signed by the main employer organisations - MEDEF (Mouvement des Entreprises de France), CGPME (Confédération Générale des Petites et Moyennes Entreprises), and UPA (Union Professionnelle Artisanale) - together with the representative trade union confederations CFDT, CFE-CGC, CFTC, CGT, and FO. The agreement laid down the foundational rules for telework, such as its voluntary nature, the principle of equal rights with on-site workers, employer responsibility for equipment and costs, guarantees of health and safety, and protection of collective rights. It served as the first structured legal basis for telework in France, later incorporated into the French Labour Code.

In 2012, the so-called Warsmann law (Law n° 2012-387 of 22 March 2012) transformed the 2005 ANI on telework into a binding law in France by incorporating its principles into the French Labour Code. The law reinforced several of the key principles of telework: telework must be voluntary and cannot be imposed unilaterally; it must be formalised through the contract, an amendment, or a collective agreement (contractualisation); and it is reversible, allowing either party to return to the previous arrangement.

In 2017, Macron's ordinances increased the flexibility of the remote work framework by differentiating between regular and occasional telework, while also reducing the need for formal contractual agreements. Instead, a common agreement between employers and employees, typically via email, is sufficient to implement remote work. It ensures the principle of double voluntariness, the individual choice of the employee who has to accept to work outside of the office, and the employer, which does not have to accept the employee's demand (under specific objective criteria). The ordinances also protect remote workers from work-related accidents when they occur during working hours. Due to the COVID-19 pandemic, in 2020, a new national interprofessional agreement reframed these rights to strengthen social dialogue. Remote work is therefore described as an attractive tool to recruit. The agreements also discussed the matters of double voluntariness, forms of agreements, refusals of remote work, adaptation periods, and reversibility. The agreement was based on the European Social Partners Framework on Digitalisation of 2020. In 2021, the

agreement for remote work for the public sector was signed. Switzerland and France have signed an agreement on teleworking provisions due to concerns regarding taxation which will come into force in 2026, after the transitional agreement ends.

The first report in France regarding remote work was published in 1993 at the demand of the government (Le Forum des droits sur l'internet, 2004). The development of remote work in France has been driven by a combination of technological, economic, and cultural factors. The widespread diffusion of digital technologies, notably high-speed internet, laptops, and collaborative platforms has made it technically possible for many jobs to be performed outside traditional workplaces.

At the same time, structural, economic evolutions have encouraged companies to adopt new forms of work organisation. Finally, a gradual change in mindsets has played a crucial role; once perceived with suspicion, it is increasingly associated with better work-life balance, reduced commuting time and increased autonomy. In 2004, 7% of the French working population worked remotely, 2 % at home, and 5 % as nomads. The majority of remote workers were executives, men, full-time, in the financial and business services sectors. In 2023, 26% of employees worked remotely, a seventeen percentage points increase compared to 2019 (Dares, 2024a). Furthermore, 51% of total remote workers are women, 61% are executives, and 17% are agents. There are fewer new remote company work agreements, with 2,080 in 2023, compared to 3,940 in 2019 (Dares, 2025a). The number of agreements increased between 2017 and 2021 (Dares, 2025a). The industry sector accounted for 550 of these agreements in 2023, compared to 980 in 2021. The number of agreements increased from 2017, with a total of 50 agreements to 490 in 2023 in the public service sector, i.e. education, health, and social services. Yet, the number of agreements in the financial and insurance sectors decreased by half, with a total of 290 agreements in 2023, compared to 470 in 2021. Two days of remote work are the most common in agreements (Dares, 2025a). Yet, remote work also presents risks, such as distancing of social relations, the increase of working time, and difficulty in achieving a work-life balance (Dares, 2025b). It can even lead to more domestic violence. However, remote work can also reduce the number of complaints from employees' partners about their working hours. In some instances, it can reduce the gender gap in unpaid domestic care work within a household (Dares, 2024b). Yet, women can also experience an increase in mental load regarding domestic work. Remote work can create difficulties for work-life balance. Among women in relationships with children under three, the time spent on unpaid domestic work remains unchanged when working remotely. These mothers often spend more time thinking about household concerns during working hours (Dares, 2024b).

Pre-COVID-19 hybrid work practice

In the early 2000s, Auxilia was a small firm composed of a dozen people with no human resources service. It is within this framework that the hybrid work model was first implemented. In the interview, the company director explained that there was no elaborate hierarchical structure in 2001.

> *When hybrid work practice was introduced, Auxilia was solely an entity composed of a few people with no HR. It was not really an elaborated hierarchical structure.*
> - General Director

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The hybrid work model was primarily based on the principle of self-organisation, allowing employees to structure their work as they saw fit to achieve their primary work objectives. For the past 18 years, Auxilia's hybrid work model has been guided by this principle and continues to uphold it.

Initially, there was no employee representation because Auxilia's structure was too small. The very first representative format was a large general meeting of all the employees. This meeting was established between 2009 and 2011 to enable social dialogue within the company and prepare for its future growth. In order to meet the legal requirements for workers' representation, two Employee representatives were appointed during the same period. These representatives played a strong role in shaping discussions regarding work-related issues and social dialogue. After the company met the legal requirements to set up a work council, elections were held and two representatives were elected.

Auxilia's working model has been developed gradually over the years. Between 2013 to 2015, remote work was included in the employees' contracts. Employees were granted flexibility in organising their work according to their mobility demands. Because many of them engage in daily business trips - often facing weeks with particularly intense commuting schedules -it is more practical for them to work remotely rather than return to the office after prolonged travel. In such circumstances, working from a café, a nearby co-working space, home, or even on a train offers considerably greater convenience and efficiency than maintaining a strict on-site presence. The company's flexible approach to remote work has been a core element of its identity since its creation. More specifically, this ethos is reflected in its hybrid working model, which is formalised in employment contracts that permit employees to work remotely for up to two days per week. As the company expanded, its working model became increasingly structured, marking a clear departure from its early years, when employees largely organised their work independently. Initially, Auxilia relied heavily on this self-directed mode of collaboration; however, over time, more formal practices emerged. For example, Monday was proposed as a designated in-person workday, the first general-meeting format was established, and social dialogue began to flourish. This evolution contrasts sharply with the situation in 2009, when the concept of hybrid working had not yet been introduced. The HR representative interviewed states that, although the possibility of working remotely was available to everyone, it was not initially widely embraced by employees, presumably because it was not part of the working culture in France, and employees preferred to come to the office.

Given the requirements to visit clients on their premises, remote work, whether undertaken from home or while travelling for business, was already practised by 30% of the workforce prior to the COVID-19 pandemic, a proportion that subsequently increased substantially. According to Auxilia's remote charter (Annex 1), remote working can be implemented during exceptional circumstances such as air pollution, strikes, or individual motives such as medical conditions. Employees working remotely are expected to stay reachable during working hours. When the pandemic broke out in 2020, remote work became the only feasible option, forcing the company to adapt to virtual meetings and new ways of collaboration.

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2 – Description of the hybrid work model

Post-COVID-19 hybrid work model

At Auxilia, employees must travel to meet clients, which necessitates a flexible organisational structure. Remote work has therefore long been implemented whenever required to enable employees to carry out their activities effectively. Following the COVID-19 pandemic, the uptake of remote work increased significantly. For example, the use of video calls to communicate with clients became more frequent, thereby reducing the need for business trips. The need for a new charter, which sets the rules for remote work at Auxilia, arose due to this contextual shift and legal changes, following staff requests and consultations with the work council. The charter was established at the initiative of management on the basis of a project of the SOS Group (Annex 1). Consultations with the works council took place in person.

Signed by management and the works council in 2021, the charter outlines the procedures for transitioning to a remote work location. These procedures require employees to submit a written digital request, accompanied by sworn statements confirming the conformity of their home working space. The charter also stipulates that employees must remain reachable during standard working hours. It also stipulated that employees will receive the digital devices used as well as the working equipment to perform their tasks. The charter was implemented immediately, without a pilot phase, as its purpose was primarily to formalise practices that had already been established. According to the company director, the hybrid work model resembles the pre-pandemic working model. In the Parisian site, Monday was proposed by the management as the day for face-to-face work, so that everyone could meet in person, specifically the management team. It is still the case. The hybrid work charter or policy is not explicitly linked to any other company strategy, whether digital or otherwise.

As consistently highlighted in the interviews, the hybrid model operates differently in practice. The company director described the organisation of hybrid work at Auxilia as a “laid-back practice”. More precisely, Auxilia’s charter states that anyone who wishes to work from home can do so, regardless of their position in the company hierarchy. As pointed out by one employee representative interviewed, some employees are likely to work around this framework as they are required to travel frequently for work-related activities. Indeed, employees can schedule their remote working days with flexibility, meaning that they can take one remote day a week and three days the following week. This flexibility is needed in the company as employees often travel for work for several days.

According to the interviewees, they also do not need to ask their manager for permission or give advance notice if they choose to work from home, unlike in many other companies. The HR representative interviewed noted that some employees work entirely remotely. However, all interviewees expressed a preference for working in the office. The director, for instance, tends to work remotely only one day per week. Yet, this can vary depending on the needs of clients. The practice of remote work varies considerably across the company, depending on both individual agencies and individual preferences. There is no common practice at the headquarters in Paris, and remote work arrangements differ according to local circumstances. For example, at the Nantes-based agency, the office location is perceived as inconvenient, leading many employees - some of whom also live far from the workplace - to opt for remote work more frequently. Employees decide

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whether to work remotely based on what best aligns with their personal circumstances and preferences. As one Employee representative emphasised, people's relationship with remote work can also vary depending on their personal circumstances. Some employees prefer traditional office work over remote work. Some individuals like to come to work to foster and maintain social relations, such as the same Employee representative, who prefers to come to the office every day except when on business trips. Similarly, the other Employee representative based in Nantes chooses to work in the office to maintain a good work-life balance. Additionally, no specific controls are exercised over employees at Auxilia as the relationship is primarily based on trust. This means that employers and employees are bound by a form of social contract, and it is assumed that employees who work remotely are actually working.

However, at agencies like Nantes, several employees work remotely from nearby cities such as Angers and Pornic, as commuting to the office in Nantes can take over an hour each way. According to the director, there is a group of workers who seldom work remotely, such as the administrative staff. Although they have the equipment to work remotely, they use it less than others for various reasons. The receptionist or secretary, for example, is required to be physically present on site and has a full office contract, meaning they must work on site five days a week without alternative arrangements. This constitutes a standard employment contract. Although interns have the right to work remotely, they do not often prefer this option and mainly work in the office, as it contributes to the added value of their internship experience. Reflecting on this, the HR representative emphasised that in Auxilia, some people are way more present in the office than others, for instance, administrative staff, interns and other employees who prefer coming to the office.

Tools and technologies used

As explained by the HR representative interviewed, the increasing practice of remote work required new adaptations within offices. Auxilia actively supports flexible work arrangements to ensure that all employees can work efficiently, whether on-site or remotely. Every team member, including those in administrative roles, is provided with a laptop. Additionally, everyone has secure access to the company network via a VPN, and all the necessary IT tools to carry out their tasks in good conditions. To enhance comfort and productivity, employees can also benefit from additional equipment such as dual monitors, ergonomic chairs, and other digital tools. Digital work and collaboration tools, including AI assistants and virtual meeting platforms, were deployed to support employees' adaptation to a hybrid work environment. Auxilia's employees also use software to calculate the time spent on each project. This enables Auxilia to calculate the number of invoiced hours (to the client) each employee works on each project. Each week, employees declare how many hours of their eight-hour day are spent on each project (or managing time for managers). However, this software does not count the actual number of hours worked, as employees can only declare the number of hours they will invoice to the client per week and not their real working time.

Future of the hybrid work model

The hybrid model of Auxilia was developed gradually and will continue to evolve in the future. In fact, Auxilia's approach to hybrid work is different when examined through its internal regulations compared to day-to-day practice. It therefore falls within two categories of hybrid work models developed for this study (Ecorys, 2024). On paper, Auxilia adopts a so-called Controlled Hybrid,

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requiring employees to be in the office on specific days depending on their role, with limited opportunities for remote work. The charter and the employment contracts allow employees to telework two days a week, while the remaining three days can be divided between office work and client-site assignments (involving travelling to the clients' premises). However, all interviewees reported that, in practice, Auxilia's hybrid model operates quite differently. Its implementation more closely resembles a Remote-Friendly Hybrid model, where work time and location are task-driven with collaboration and flexibility based mainly on autonomy and results. However, given employees' high level of autonomy and the strong reliance on online collaboration, Auxilia's model also approaches a fully flexible model, as some employees work from home on a daily basis.

At the time of the interviews, there were no current plans by management, Employee representatives, or employees to amend the company's hybrid work model. However, it is important to note that the future of the hybrid work model at Auxilia might change due to the misalignment between its formal remote work framework and its actual implementation. However, other factors besides the mismatch between Auxilia's theoretical and documented hybrid work model might cause it to change in the future. Indeed, other factors may also influence Auxilia's hybrid policy, for instance, an increase in its workforce, a change in the French legal regulations or the pressure from clients in the framework of the generalisation of return-to-office practices. Taking these into account, the future of Auxilia's hybrid work model is somewhat uncertain.

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3 – Organisational outcomes

Efficiency and workflow changes

In a team of engaged and skilled workers, there are complaints about the high workload and the intensity of business trips, which can harm work-life balance and productivity. According to the Auxilia's barometer - an external tool administered biannually to assess factors such as working conditions, autonomy, stress levels, and work-life balance - employees report that work-life balance is relatively weak, largely due to the high number of business trips. Employee representative 1 highlighted the limited enforcement of work contracts, noting that many employees report working overtime without financial compensation. This situation is partly linked to the absence of a working time tracking system, which means that employees' working hours are not systematically recorded. Some employees worry that the company's model might not remain viable if working hours were formally tracked. This concern is shared by the director, who has expressed doubts about the sustainability of the operational model if hours are systematically counted.

Employees frequently travel to visit clients and assist with running meetings and workshops. They also commute throughout the year to participate in collective gatherings. According to the HR representative, these gatherings enable employees to connect with one another. Lab parties offer opportunities for collective reflection on new approaches to consultancy work, whilst winter and summer seminars, internal to the company, deal with different topics such as team dynamics, budgets, company performance, and major development projects. Employee representative 2 notes that commuting can also support work-life balance, and lots of projects are organised in teams to mitigate the risk of isolation.

Due to the demands imposed by the company's clientele, employees are often expected to work longer hours, which can lead to overwork and reduced workflow efficiency. Management conducts an annual review of these issues and shares its findings with the works council, where overwork frequently emerges as a central topic, particularly in discussions on prevention strategies. In response, the works council has introduced an overwork assessment grid designed to help prevent burnout.

Despite these efforts, the calculation of working hours - whether daily, hourly, or in relation to overtime - remains a source of tension between Employee representatives and management. The line manager, however, views working hours as more of a discussion point than a conflict, suggesting that difficulties often arise because younger employees may struggle to set boundaries or to request time off. According to Employee representative 2 in Nantes, these challenges are prompting a broader reconsideration of how work is organised at Auxilia.

Communication and collaboration dynamics

As reported by the Employee representative based in Nantes and the company's director, some individuals are more present at the office than others. Auxilia's agency in Nantes employs ten people, and attendance varies greatly depending on employee preferences. For example, two workers based in Angers regularly opt for remote work to avoid long commutes, thereby saving time and enabling them to be more productive in their work. However, employees who choose to work 100% remotely tend to become more isolated, as they do not work in direct contact with their

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colleagues and effectively operate outside the core working community. As a result, they have very limited interaction with other employees. According to an interviewee, these situations create inequalities in cohesion and teamwork, particularly when some employees come to the office only once or twice a month.

According to most interviewees, either managers or consultants, employees working mainly remotely are prone to experiencing more isolation from work collective. Those who work from home may be less involved than others in Auxilia's internal life, including informal initiatives and events such as mini conferences. As noted by Employee representative 2, this could lead to the perception that they are less engaged or disconnected from Auxilia's life. The HR representative emphasised that remote work has given way to the development of an "asymmetry of relations". This issue has surfaced in several agencies, including Nantes, Bordeaux and Lyon, and has been the subject of discussions among employees within these agencies. This difference in an employee's integration within their team can lead to differences in their level of commitment to the company, resulting in different treatment between those who work remotely and those in the office. However, this issue has not yet been discussed at the work council or company level.

Although there are risks associated with full-time remote work, no specific issues have been formally reported to the management so far. Employee representative 1 reports that overall working conditions and communication with Auxilia are positive. She even describes these as "peaceful dialogues", despite some disagreements on substance. Managers and employees are used to communicating and monitoring progress remotely during monthly meetings. For instance, Employee representative's 1 manager is currently based in Brittany, while she works in a different region. Although the distance does not impede communication, she explains that remote interactions are not as fluid as in-person. Discussions tend to be more open face-to-face than through screens, where a certain aspect of human connection is lost.

At Auxilia, workers communicate and collaborate as part of collective tasks. To illustrate this work dynamic, Employee Representative 1 mentioned that various projects are implemented in teams. Line manager 2 stated that it is essential for employees to communicate with their manager. They should open up about the difficulties they face with hybrid working.

Company culture and team cohesion

Auxilia's culture is deeply rooted in the principles of autonomy and flexibility, which have long been embedded in the organisation and formalised through employment contracts. These values are further reinforced in the company's charter, which serves as a key reference document. The director emphasises that hybrid working and the key role of field missions increase employees' motivation. Although consulting work culture can be demanding - characterised by high expectations, tight deadlines, and the need for adaptability, the freedom of organising one's work remains a cornerstone of Auxilia's company culture is highly appreciated by its staff.

In this context, line managers describe employees as highly qualified, enthusiastic and committed. Similarly, Employee Representative 1 adds that employees are highly motivated by their work, particularly in areas such as the green transition and consulting missions for local authorities. However, Line Manager 2 acknowledges that some people are less motivated. She explains that this situation is difficult to manage, especially when employees work remotely. According to her, this lack of drive and engagement can stem from various factors. The geographical distance preventing

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employees from regularly coming to the office, combined with the constant practice of remote work, can negatively affect the integration of some employees into team dynamics. In small agencies, building a collective work dynamic - particularly in terms of fostering regular team interactions - can be particularly challenging when all three or four team members work remotely. Employees' choice to work remotely on a full-time basis can have negative consequences for the team, increasing feelings of loneliness and isolation. Specifically, those who come to the office may suffer from a lack of in-person interaction with their colleagues who work remotely, while remote workers can experience similar feelings, as their engagement is limited to virtual discussions.

To address these challenges, the director explains that adaptive measures can be implemented to support employees, particularly in situations where personal circumstances, such as the burden of relentless commuting for young parents or a return from maternity leave, require adjustments. Such measures rely on active communication between the employee and their manager. To reinforce this dialogue, the company has strengthened its communication channels through dedicated 'employee-manager meeting sessions'. In addition, managers participate in training sessions organised by the SOS Group and conduct similar sessions internally, enhancing their capacity to respond effectively to a wide range of employee needs.

The director further highlights that health and safety at work remain central concerns for the company, representing a twofold challenge: (i) retention, by ensuring that employees remain committed over the long term, and (ii) exemplarity, by upholding strong environmental and social standards across the company's projects.

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4 – Organisational and management challenges

Digital infrastructure and communication tools

At Auxilia, various digital tools are used to support project management, communication, and time tracking. Software is used to record working time invoiced to customers and ensure that annual objectives are met. According to one of the Employee representatives interviewed, the tool is rigid, obsolete, unreliable and unsuitable for measuring and recording working hours. Additionally, they point out that the software is particularly anxiety-inducing due to its complexity. Broader concerns relate to compensation and workload, with employees, especially those on hourly contracts, reportedly being overworked and underpaid, contributing to elevated levels of burnout and sick leave. These issues have been raised by Employee representatives with management, which at this stage does not intend to modify the system for calculating invoiced hours to allow it to also be used for calculating hours worked.

In consulting, each project is allocated a certain number of working days. For instance, in a 10-day project, each day consists of eight hours of work. The total amount of working time must result in five days a week. As explained by the Employee representative based in Nantes, employees are asked to enter their work time per project on a weekly basis, using eighths of a day as the unit of measure. The work council wished to follow legal guidelines to count the number of hours worked and quantify overtime. The high workload in the company can lead to exhaustion and a lack of trust between employees and management, particularly because employees may feel that they are not being paid enough for the time they work or may be disappointed that they do not receive a day off in lieu after working overtime on several occasions. Since employees work remotely or off-site, they have fewer opportunities to compare their working hours with those of their colleagues. This limited visibility into others' workloads makes it more difficult to identify situations of overwork and to prevent potential burnout.

Several initiatives support internal communication. As explained by the HR representative, a weekly internal newsletter discusses key news, workforce information, and new developments in their areas of expertise. Additionally, a flash news meeting is organised in a hybrid format to ensure that remote employees can connect and participate. These one-hour group discussions mainly focus on current topics relevant to the life of the company and are also shared in a written form.

The company is particularly invested in AI issues. As stated by the director, Auxilia encourages employees to resort to AI tools without being mandatory. Monthly training sessions are offered by an internal AI expert, focusing on various practical applications. Two years prior, Auxilia set up a working group to explore environmental and ethical dimensions of AI use. This is part of a process of experimentation and capitalisation. Employees have access to company accounts on generative AI tools and utilise these applications, for example, to create slide decks. Regular meetings are organised to present AI usage frameworks, such as knowledge-sharing practices and digital upskilling initiatives, which employees reportedly find particularly valuable. According to interviewees, however, no formal process is currently in place to ensure the responsible use of generative AI. Instead, the company relies on a culture of trust, with best practices being discussed and collectively defined during these regular meetings dedicated to AI usage. To further communicate, employees and managers rely on online meeting platforms and digital collaboration tools. They also make use

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of a standard office productivity suite.

➞***Management challenges***

The company faces several interrelated management challenges arising from its reliance on digital tools in a hybrid work context. The absence of an efficient system for tracking working hours, along with budgeting software that is perceived as rigid, unreliable, and anxiety-inducing, creates additional difficulties in a remote environment where employees depend heavily on digital systems to record and coordinate their activities. These challenges are compounded by high work demands, particularly in consulting projects, which contribute to overwork, underpayment concerns, and heightened risks of burnout and sick leave. Hybrid work further reduces day-to-day visibility into employees' workloads, making it harder to identify early signs of strain, ensure equitable work distribution, and maintain trust. Although internal communication initiatives aim to strengthen cohesion, sustaining collective dynamics and a shared sense of organisational belonging remains difficult in a geographically dispersed workforce.

Office space and on-site work environment

Some employees chose to work remotely as much as possible in the aftermath of the pandemic because, in their view, the office was not sufficiently equipped to accommodate new working practices, particularly the rapid and significant rise in remote meetings. This is why, since 2022–2023, Auxilia's main offices have readjusted their work environment to better support these changes. Auxilia strives to cater for workers' needs by setting up quiet workplaces in its agencies that are adapted to hybrid work practices. The layout has reportedly been adapted to the rise of hybrid work, ensuring that the surge in virtual meetings is no longer a constraint, especially for those working on-site. For example, in addition to the aforementioned new tools and technologies, phone boxes have been installed to support new hybrid working practices, such as the increase in video calls. The HR Director asserted that if an employee wishes to come to the office every day, this is at his own initiative. In addition, he clarified that each employee naturally has a workspace and a desk, and Auxilia provides support for technical setup.

According to two interviewees from the management, the office layout has now been adapted so that the increase in virtual meetings is no longer a constraint, particularly for those working in the office. For the HR Director, the 'balance has been achieved'. According to Line Manager 2, consulting firms usually use this kind of hybrid model, particularly nowadays, and there are no existing obstacles to this approach.

As in all French companies, Auxilia is required to establish and maintain the Document Unique d'Évaluation des Risques Professionnels (DUERP), in accordance with the Labour Code (Code du travail, articles R.4121-1 to R.4121-4; Decree n°2001-1016 of 5 November 2001). This mandatory document identifies and evaluates occupational risks and must be updated at least once a year, as well as whenever major changes in work organisation occur. In the context of hybrid and remote work, the DUERP must explicitly address risks such as ergonomic concerns, psychosocial risks, and digital overload to ensure compliance with occupational health and safety regulations. At the time of writing, the company's DUERP includes measures related to the prevention of psychosocial risks and workplace ergonomics arising from its hybrid work policy. Interviews highlighted several psychosocial risks experienced by employees, including heavy workload, burnout, anxiety, feelings of

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pressure or discomfort, work–life imbalance, isolation, and an intense work pace. Although employees did not refer to a regular formal risk assessment beyond the DUERP updates, they reported the existence of regular meetings between employees and managers, as well as the use of an external 'barometer' tool. This barometer, administered every two years, evaluates working conditions, autonomy, stress and anxiety levels, and work-life balance. The latest results indicate that employees are concerned about salary recognition and difficulties in achieving an adequate work–life balance.

➞ ***Management challenges***

The main management challenge lies in adapting the physical and organisational work environment to hybrid work in a way that ensures both effective collaboration and employee well-being. Following the pandemic, some employees avoided the office because it was not sufficiently equipped to support new hybrid practices, prompting the company to retrofit its workspace with quiet areas, phone booths, and updated digital tools. While these adjustments aim to reduce constraints linked to virtual meetings and encourage office attendance, the organisation must also simultaneously address the psychosocial risks exacerbated by hybrid work, such as a heavy workload, burnout, anxiety, isolation, and work-life imbalance. Ensuring compliance with legal risk assessment obligations (via the DUERP) and responding to employee concerns highlighted in the biennial barometer add further complexity. Thus, the challenge is to maintain an environment - both physical and psychosocial - that supports hybrid work without compromising employee health, cohesion, or fairness.

Remote work settings

Although rarely practised before the COVID-19 pandemic, remote work at Auxilia had always been possible, but relatively little used in practice, supported by the broader principle of flexible work organisation. This was estimated at around 30% of the workforce using remote work for an average of one day per week, by the HR director. The company not only provided employees with essential tools for remote work, such as laptop computers, basic office supplies, and technologies for virtual meetings, but also reinforced its longstanding emphasis on autonomy in organising one's work, which remains central to its remote work practices.

However, the frequency of travel, which can range from one to three times per week according to Employee representative 1, can negatively impact remote work, as working conditions on a train, for example, are not as optimal compared to those in a dedicated workspace. The HR Director highlights certain issues related to remote work, particularly the absence of occupancy allowances - payments intended to compensate employees for the costs of using a workspace outside the company - as well as the lack of reimbursement for expenses such as internet connection, electricity, and heating when working from home. According to him, these expenses are not reimbursed because remote work, while encouraged, is not imposed by the company and is instead implemented at the employee's initiative[3]. While working from home offers comfort and reduces fatigue from commuting, it also

[3] Legally speaking there is no obligation to reimburse such expenses. But the National interprofessional agreement on telework of 26 November 2020 open the door for reimbursements with room for discussion and social dialogue. Its article 3.1.5 about "Coverage of professional expenses" stresses that "the principle that expenses incurred by an employee in the

entails higher personal costs, a trade-off that persists despite the company supporting this practice through its remote work charter. When examining remote work settings and challenges, one of the Employee representatives interviewed also explained that employment contracts with a fixed hourly rate (forfait heures) are not adapted to consultancies involving business travels (e.g., participation in group meetings and field missions). The Employee representatives find the formula unsuitable because client meetings and travel time exceed the number of hours provided for in the fixed hourly rate. It should be noted that employees on a fixed hourly rate do not ask to benefit from it. This formula is imposed on them by the sectoral collective agreement. On the other hand, these overruns lead them to request a record of working hours to show the overruns and hope to receive compensation in time or money (payment of overtime). Employees are likely to work late some weeks due to workshops ending late in the evening. Certain weeks can be quite long, averaging 39 to 40 working hours compared to the standard 35-hour week provided in the employment contract of employees on a fixed hourly rate. These working conditions and hours differ significantly when working remotely. These factors can significantly influence workloads and work-life balance, which represent primary points of concern among employees. The HR representative pointed out that one of his colleagues has been on medical leave for several months and hypothesised that the cause may be excessive workload and blurred boundaries between work and private life.

➞ ***Management challenges***

Although remote work is supported through flexible organisation and access to equipment, hybrid practices are undermined by mobility demands, as working conditions during travel are far less optimal than in a dedicated workspace. Financial equity also emerges as an issue: because remote work is encouraged but not mandated, home-working expenses, such as heating, electricity, and internet, are not reimbursed, shifting the costs of hybrid work onto employees.

Contractual constraints further complicate matters. Employees on fixed hourly-rate contracts (forfait heures) frequently exceed their contractual hours due to client meetings, travel, and workshops that run late, yet overtime is not automatically compensated. This contributes to weeks of 39-40 hours instead of the standard 35 hours, raising risks of overwork and work–life imbalance. These pressures are heightened in hybrid contexts, where blurred life-work boundaries can negatively affect health, as illustrated by recent cases of long-term medical leave.

In this context, the management challenge lies in ensuring that employees meet work demands without compromising their health and well-being. Managers reported relying primarily on *management de proximité* - frequent and direct communication with employees - to monitor workloads, detect early signs of strain, and provide support in a dispersed working environment.

performance of their employment contract must be borne by the employer applies to all work situations. As such, it is the responsibility of the company to cover expenses incurred by the employee for the purposes of their professional activity and in the interests of the company, after approval by the employer. The choice of how to cover professional expenses may, where applicable, be a subject for social dialogue within the company. Any lump sum allowance paid by the employer to reimburse the employee is deemed to have been used for its intended purpose and is exempt from social security contributions and contributions within the limits provided for by law".

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5 - Managerial practices and strategies

Challenges and changes in roles and leadership style of line managers

The company fosters a strong sense of proximity between managers and employees, which has become a key tool for addressing the challenges of hybrid work. Although the organisational structure is flexible and employees enjoy considerable autonomy, this proximity is maintained through structured monthly meetings, held either in person or online, in which managers and employees review workloads, business travel, and other operational matters. These regular check-ins provide consistent managerial oversight and support across different working arrangements.

In this context, the management function has expanded beyond traditional task supervision to encompass sustained, high-quality communication with each team member. This approach requires greater attention to employees' perceptions of workload, their ability to meet deadlines, and early signs of disengagement. As a result, leadership styles have shifted towards a more empathetic model grounded in trust, active listening, and adaptability to individual circumstances.

According to Line Manager 2, managers must also be able to detect early signs of disengagement or distress. As the HR representative noted, most issues can be addressed at the managerial level, with further involvement from human resources when necessary. Line Manager 2 further explained that manager-employee meetings provide opportunities to discuss questions related to hybrid work, including the challenges it creates, workload pressures, and perceived stress. These structured exchanges enable managers to closely monitor emerging difficulties, such as missed deadlines or reduced thoroughness, and to identify potential signs of disengagement or burnout. When such issues arise, managers are expected to report them to their superiors. Managers themselves meet weekly, both within their areas of expertise and with senior management, to discuss relevant concerns.

Management of well-being in the hybrid work model

Impact of hybrid work on management practices

Auxilia's hybrid work model has several implications for management practices. Management is intrinsically characterised by flexibility and closeness, with all interviewees emphasising that flexibility and autonomy lie at the centre of the organisation's managerial approach. However, despite the availability of remote work, office-based work remains the preferred option for many employees. According to Employee representative 1, physical presence is particularly important when supervising interns, as it facilitates orientation, mentorship, and daily support. She therefore encourages interns to work on-site while still allowing them the option to work remotely a few days per week when needed.

Line Manager 2 similarly stresses the importance of proximity in consultancy work, noting that close relations between managers and employees are essential for monitoring well-being and preventing overwork. Physical proximity also enhances communication frequency, including informal exchanges, which hybrid arrangements can otherwise limit. This proximity enables managers to identify employees' needs more effectively and, when necessary, adjust working conditions, such as

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reducing business travel, to prevent excessive strain. In cases of burnout, managers collaborate with human resources to maintain employee engagement and provide tailored support.

When asked about hybrid work practices across the company, interviewees were unable to identify a common pattern. Aside from a few exceptions - employees who work almost exclusively remotely or, conversely, have roles requiring constant on-site presence - most staff adopt a mixed approach combining office work, occasional remote work, and frequent business travel. While many expressed a personal preference for office work due to the benefits of team closeness and improved work–life balance, no uniform trend or standard practice could be established across the organisation.

Within Auxilia, employees may serve as project chiefs or project directors, responsible for ensuring that projects progress as planned and that deadlines are met. Line managers, by contrast, focus primarily on the employees themselves, ensuring that their workloads are appropriate and not overwhelming. Although managers also monitor ongoing projects, they do so from a distinct perspective - one centred on employee well-being rather than project delivery.

At Auxilia, a manager oversees each area of expertise, while project chiefs or directors coordinate the implementation of work tasks, organise team requirements, and schedule meetings. Depending on the nature of the project, Line Manager 2 monitors her team's activities to ensure balanced workloads and a clear distribution of tasks. As a result, each employee benefits from multiple layers of supervision, including both managerial and project-based oversight. Employees are also embedded in larger groups aligned with their areas of expertise, making motivation and integration essential. When individuals appear isolated or less engaged, managers discuss these issues with them and may encourage them to maintain a greater office presence.

As the director explained, monthly follow-up meetings (PIMS) between managers and individual employees are organised to address matters such as work organisation and travel arrangements. These meetings are especially important given that many managers and employees are not based in the same agency. Structured around a shared presentation slideshow, the PIMS meetings ensure that managers systematically address a broad range of topics, maintain consistent monitoring across the organisation, and provide a clear framework for discussion.

As explained by Employee representative 2, about half of the managers work remotely. However, they do not note any differences between remote and direct management relations. According to Employee representative 1, remote management relations have complications as they depersonalise relations. She believes that conversations in the office flow more easily than online meetings. Without the opportunity for informal discussion, employees are less able to foster connections and improve morale. Expertise directors should visit once a month, but often do not, only sometimes during internal seminars. As explained by the HR representative, most challenges, such as high/low workload, stress, fatigue, burnout, too much/little business travel, can be resolved by managers. If required, directors and staff managers can intervene. Auxilia's director specifies that he participates in training sessions organised by Group SOS on topics such as management efficiency and psychosocial risks.

As stated by the Director, team meetings in Paris are held on Mondays. In addition, a weekly meeting brings together all managers and intermediate management to discuss issues such as burnout and cross-functional expertise topics. Other occasions and events throughout the year also require team participation. The company has two seminars per year. The company also organises three so-called lab parties. As the HR representative explains, these parties are organised to

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structure and share innovation, such as working methods, and to reflect on new ways of providing consulting services and meeting clients' needs. As part of the SOS Group, Auxilia participates in a collective day with employees from other companies within the Group.

The increase in remote work following the pandemic has heightened awareness of the importance of maintaining a presence in the office. The Director thus considers it part of his role to remain visible on-site and to adopt flexible working hours. Additionally, as noted by the Employee representative 2, employees can raise concerns during the so-called 'Fast-CODEV'. These meetings allow employees to present issues to their peers, with each session centred on a specific problem or challenge. However, hybrid work has never been the focus. In response to the loss of shared collective moments brought about by hybrid work, the company has strengthened internal communication and transparency through its "Auxilia news" newsletter. As explained by the HR representatives, the newsletter provides updates on current events and company finances and serves as a mechanism to ensure the flow of information, reinforce transparency, and facilitate discussion about the company's future. In this sense, the newsletter plays an important role in maintaining communication within a hybrid work model.

Several issues were identified within the company, some of which relate specifically to hybrid work while others stem from the broader nature of consultancy activities, such as frequent travel and fluctuating workloads. It remains difficult to determine which challenges are directly attributable to the hybrid model, as the organisation has long been structured around flexibility and mobility. Managers appear to be partially prepared for these dynamics, yet the evolution of their role is hard to assess, given that proximity management has historically been a core feature of the company.

Office presence plays an important role in mitigating psychosocial risks. As the Director noted, employees often report that "real work" occurs not only through formal tasks but also through informal interactions at coffee machines and during breaks, which foster collaboration and cohesion - elements more difficult to maintain in hybrid settings. Employee well-being is also seen as essential for reducing turnover and increasing retention, and human resources periodically monitor working conditions through surveys. Remote work at home, however, requires appropriate ergonomic conditions and tools such as screens and suitable furniture, as highlighted by Employee representative 2.

Workload regulation is an ongoing challenge. Each manager is responsible for addressing issues related to overtime and excessive workloads. Managers can redistribute tasks within their area of expertise when discrepancies arise or escalate concerns to higher management if workload imbalances extend across the organisation. Although a software tool is intended to track working hours and signal high workloads, it reportedly functions poorly in practice.

Hybrid work also intensifies disparities across agencies. While employees maintain a relatively stable presence at the Paris headquarters, smaller agencies may experience reduced office attendance. According to the Employee representative in Nantes, this has contributed to weakened communication with management and diminished team cohesion. A recent example involved the Nantes agency director's prolonged sick leave, which led to a breakdown in communication between Paris and the local team, leaving employee concerns unaddressed.

Ensuring adequate rest time presents another difficulty. After business trips or atypical working hours, employees may request compensatory rest; however, such requests are often inconsistently granted. As described by Employee representative 2, the criteria for approving rest time are unclear

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and appear arbitrary. He recounted a case from June 2024, in which his initial request to recover extra hours was rejected on the grounds that such practices are reserved for urgent situations, such as tender submissions. The decision was reversed only after the manager perceived his frustration. Although taking rest time is possible, the lack of transparent rules complicates employees' ability to plan and recover their hours, particularly in a hybrid and travel-intensive work environment.

Supporting managers in a hybrid work model

Several measures have been implemented to ensure employees' well-being and support managers.

Line Manager 2 noted that managers have a 'difficult job', as they must remain constantly vigilant during managerial interactions and attentive to any signs of employee distress. To support these responsibilities, managers benefit from reduced productivity objectives, allowing them to dedicate more time to management tasks and consequently less to project work compared to other employees. Within this framework, issues related to workload monitoring and the discrepancy between real and prescribed working time are addressed. Ultimately, the effective functioning of remote work depends largely on managers, who play a central role in ensuring that hybrid arrangements operate smoothly. Their role is particularly crucial for younger employees, who have less experience managing work–life balance and workload demands - a significant consideration given that most employees are under 35 years old.

Additionally, the company monitors employee well-being through a survey conducted every two years at the SOS Group level to assess working conditions, particularly including autonomy, stress levels, work-life balance and other factors. The latest results from this tool date back to late 2022 and early 2023, with new results expected this year, as the new barometer was carried out in July 2025, with a 33% turnout in four days among the 50 employees from Auxilia (i.e about 18 employees have answered). Sensitive issues generally emerge from this barometer and concern, among other things, the level of salary recognition and work-life balance. Work trips can heavily affect work-life balance, especially for parents. For example, young employees and mothers have reported experiencing fatigue. Indeed, after the third month coming back from maternity leave, young mothers often struggle to balance family responsibilities with client-related travels. In contrast, junior employees are more frequently assigned business trips according to one interviewed line manager. Nevertheless, managers face ongoing challenges in reconciling employees' need for autonomy with the organisational imperative to monitor and high workloads.

As part of the discussions on how to prevent situations of overwork, an agreement between management and the works council has been reached on implementing a tool: an overwork assessment grid. This grid is handed out to the teams, who then carry out a form of self-assessment. Additionally, Auxilia collaborated with the Aract of Île-de-France, one of the National Agency's regional agencies for improving working conditions, which caters to small and medium enterprises by sharing training, tools, and studies. The agency worked with the work council to create an action plan to prevent psychosocial risks. Managers and Employee representatives were trained. This training included tools to raise awareness of psychosocial risks provided by Aract. The action plan defined with the Aract was presented and discussed with the whole team in a seminar. According to Line Manager 2, managers can also find support within the SOS Group to benefit from legal resources and complex human resource matters.

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Another tool, the 360° questionnaire, is completed by an employee's colleagues and is designed to gather comprehensive feedback on individual performance and contributions. According to the HR representative, this tool enables managers to gain a broader perspective on their employees' contributions, beyond their own interactions with them. This is particularly useful in organisations where managers and employees are in different locations and do not necessarily work together on the same projects. It aims to ensure that there are no deviations in terms of quality of life at work (e.g., fatigue, number of business trips, number of projects, etc).

Managers are equipped with indicators that provide information about employees' workload and involvement in work, as the number of invoiced hours. Additionally, managers monitor employee productivity by using software that produces yearly and monthly reports.

Managers are also supported by the works council by reporting information from the field to their knowledge. Auxilia's management reports relevant information to the work council representatives once a year. The relationship between the work council and management benefits from strong communication. The work council has a monthly meeting with management. Of the four members present, half of the eight members of the council (4 members and 4 deputy members) rotate to ease workload charges, increase motivation and enhance transparency.

Recommendations for managers

The current hybrid work model is not devoid of shortcomings Employee Representative 1 explains that managers sometimes lack guidance on how to respond to questions related to hybrid work, such as what to do in the event of an accident while working remotely. According to the interviewee, this issue has to do with a lack of internal training for managers and a lack of guidance in such a specific situation not covered by the remote work charter. In addition, there is no obligation for managers to discuss remote work as part of the monthly check-up with employees.

Regarding potential initiatives, one Employee representative emphasised the importance of adhering to the terms of employment contracts in order to counteract high levels of physical absence from the office. Employees should strive to comply with these contractual expectations, and any proposal requiring staff to come to the office once a week, whether on a fixed day or a flexible basis, should originate from management or emerge through collective discussion among colleagues. Ensuring that small groups of three or four employees are present in the office periodically was viewed as essential for maintaining team cohesion. These considerations are particularly relevant to discussions about the future direction of the company's hybrid work model.

While efforts have been made to adapt the workload of employees with young families, especially mothers coming back from maternity leave, cases of burnout and overwork are still present. After returning from leave, the work rhythm resumes at its usual pace after a few months. As explained by Employee Representative 1, business trips can lead to significant pressure. Despite the flexibility at Auxilia, it is essential that these workers can benefit from regular rest periods. Similar concerns are key for new and young employees. Indeed, as stated by the HR representative, it is essential to integrate new employees into the team during onboarding sessions and the trial period to strengthen relations before they work remotely.

Another point of concern is the hiring of new employees. Hybrid models enable Auxilia to widen its hiring scope, as Line manager 2 explained. However, various questions regarding additional cost coverage, such as travel coverage to the employee's office remains unclear. Similarly, managers also

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cope with uncertainties regarding cost coverage during business trips. For instance, employees sometimes buy coffee to charge their computers and work in a coffee shop. However, there is no clear understanding of the company's coverage policies.

Lastly, there are legal uncertainties regarding the lack of an efficient hour-counting system at Auxilia. According to the law and EU case law, working hours should be monitored. Geographically related salary differences between employees based in different agencies are also a topic of discussion among employees. Indeed, the differences are often justified due to changes in the cost of living, yet they raise questions regarding pay transparency.

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6 – Lessons learned and key takeaways

Hybrid work models are inherently fluid and require adaptation beyond what is prescribed in written charters or policies. Formal documents can provide structure, but they cannot fully account for the diversity of roles, mobility requirements, and personal circumstances found within an organisation. In this company's case, although a hybrid work charter exists, its application must be adapted in practice; for example, managers adjust expectations regarding office presence depending on project needs, travel schedules, or the specific support required by interns and junior staff. Similarly, remote work remains at the employee's initiative, leading to variations in how often individuals come on-site. These adaptations illustrate that hybrid work policies function best as flexible frameworks rather than rigid rules, enabling organisations to accommodate varied needs while maintaining coherence. However, this need for adaptation must not overshadow the rules that ensure a certain degree of equality and provide a frame of reference. Beyond an 'excess' of flexibility in the application of collectively agreed rules, there is a risk that some employees will no longer understand the reasons for flexibility, which may lead them to favour case-by-case treatment and accept unjustified exceptions. A balance must therefore be struck between the flexibility that justifies deviating from certain legal or contractual rules, and the 'social justice' or fairness that must be respected in practice in order to maintain trust within the working community.

Hybrid work requires structured routines to support well-being and cohesion. Even in organisations where remote work is functioning well, establishing core working hours, regular interactions, and a minimum level of in-person presence is essential for maintaining engagement and preventing isolation. At the company, this has been achieved through practices such as weekly team meetings (e.g., Monday management meetings in Paris), monthly one-to-one follow-ups between managers and employees, and the encouragement of periodic office attendance - ensuring that small groups of colleagues are present on-site at least occasionally. These structured routines help maintain a sense of collective belonging within a hybrid work environment.

Proximity management remains essential in hybrid settings. Regular one-to-one meetings between managers and employees, whether online or on-site, are central to monitoring workloads, detecting early signs of distress, and sustaining a people-centred management approach. Hybrid work demands differentiated managerial skills, as digital communication lacks the informal cues present in face-to-face interactions. At Auxilia, managers hold monthly individual meetings (PIMS) structured by a standardised slideshow, enabling systematic discussion of workload, travel schedules, stress, and work organisation. The company also clearly distinguishes between *project managers* (project chiefs or directors), who oversee project delivery, deadlines, and task coordination, and *people managers*, who focus on employee well-being, workload balance, and professional development. While project managers ensure that work progresses, people managers ensure that employees are not overworked, that their working conditions remain sustainable, and that any signs of disengagement or stress are detected early.

Vulnerable workers require additional guidance. Interns and early-career employees benefit from explicit coaching on setting boundaries, managing workloads, and requesting support. Hybrid environments can obscure informal learning opportunities, making open communication and on-site presence particularly valuable for skill development. In the interviews, some management representatives expressed a preference for junior staff to work at the office, as this enables them to

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provide more effective orientation and mentoring. While interns may work remotely a few days per week, physical co-presence is viewed as essential for their learning and integration. In addition, young mother returning at work also need work organisation adaptation, as much as it is economically feasible for the company, to avoid exposition to psychosocial risks.

Geographical flexibility has both benefits and drawbacks. While hybrid work broadens recruitment pools, dispersed workforces may face unequal commuting burdens, increased fatigue, reduced office presence, and potentially higher operational costs. Geographic variations in cost of living may also fuel debates around salary transparency. At Auxilia, employees from the Nantes agency often work remotely because the office location is inconvenient and some live far away, leading to fatigue and reduced on-site presence. This dispersion has also fuelled discussions about geographic salary differences and transparency across agencies.

Legal and contractual frameworks may not align with hybrid realities. Ambiguities in national legislation and sectoral agreements can create uncertainty around working time monitoring, overtime compensation, and the suitability of fixed-hour arrangements for consultancy roles. Broader adoption of annual working-day systems may better reflect project-based work, but policy clarity is needed. At Auxilia, employees working under fixed hourly-rate contracts (*forfait heures*) frequently exceed their contractual hours due to travel and client meetings, yet they cannot easily claim overtime because their contract type is imposed by the sectoral agreement. At the company, employees regularly report weeks of 39-40 hours instead of the contractual 35 due to late-running workshops or extended travel. Management does not systematically track working hours, despite EU-level requirements, creating legal ambiguity. Systems such as fixed- annual working-day contracts may also obscure excessive workloads, especially when combined with frequent travel, late meetings, or blurred work–life boundaries

Monitoring psychosocial risks is critical. Hybrid work can intensify risks such as work-life imbalance, isolation, and overwhelming workloads, particularly for groups like young parents. The company monitors such risks through its legally mandated *Document Unique d'Évaluation des Risques Professionnels* (DUERP), a compulsory register in French organisations that identifies and evaluates occupational risks, including those related to hybrid and remote work (e.g., ergonomic issues, digital overload, and psychosocial strain). In addition to strictly complying with legal obligations, management is making significant efforts to identify and limit psychosocial risks, in particular through training, regular communication, individual interviews on workload, and meetings with all employees.

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Annex I

CHARTER ON REMOTE WORK AT AUXILIA[4]

PREAMBLE This charter is in particular in accordance with the provisions of Law No. 2012-387 of 22 March 2012, which followed on from the national interprofessional agreement (ANI) on teleworking of 19 July 2005, and Macron Order No. 2017-1387 of 22 September 2017. It was drawn up at the request of the staff, and after consultation with the staff delegation of the Social and Economic Committee, in order to regulate teleworking within the AUXILIA association, in accordance with Article L 1222-9 of the Labour Code. Considered a modern form of organisation, teleworking aims to improve working conditions by providing greater flexibility in the exercise of professional activities and a better work-life balance. Furthermore, in line with the values promoted by the association, teleworking contributes to the preservation of the environment and reduces the risk of commuting accidents, as this organisational model leads to a reduction in home-to-work travel. It is also understood that teleworking must preserve social cohesion and the smooth running of each department and service. In addition, teleworking must be based on working relationships founded on responsibility, autonomy and trust. It is agreed that teleworking shall be made available to job profiles that are fully compatible with this mode of organisation, as follows:

ARTICLE 1: Definitions

Telework is defined by Article L 1222-9 of the Labour Code. It refers to any form of work organisation in which work that could have been performed on the employer's premises is carried out by an employee outside these premises on a voluntary basis using information and communication technologies. An employee who performs telework as defined in this charter, either from the date of hire or at a later date, is considered a teleworker.

ARTICLE 2: Conditions for transition to remote working

ARTICLE 2-1: Eligibility criteria

Firstly, the parties reiterate that: − The fundamental principle in assessing the eligibility of positions remains the priority given to customer service and satisfaction; − Teleworking implies that the employee's work can be carried out remotely, while ensuring continuity of operations and social cohesion; − Activities that by their nature require the physical presence of the employee at their place of work or in the field are not eligible; − Temporary workers are not covered by this measure.

In addition, it is specified that employees who meet all of the following conditions are eligible for telework: they have an employment contract with the association, regardless of seniority, they can perform their duties independently, partially and regularly from a distance, and their position and activities are compatible with this way of working. Holders of work-study contracts (apprenticeships, professional training, CIFRE agreements, etc.) and interns are also eligible for teleworking provided that their individual support and training allow it. In any case, teleworking must not interfere with the functioning of the work unit. Employees whose work, by its nature, must be carried out on the association's premises, such as receptionists, are not eligible. Therefore, receptionists and reception agents are not eligible for telework.

[4] Official name in French is: “Charte sur le télétravail Auxilia”

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ARTICLE 2-2: Frequency and number of teleworking days for employees who telework on a regular basis

Teleworking is limited to two days per week, and teleworking days do not have to be fixed from one week to the next. For organisational reasons, the choice of teleworking days is decided by mutual agreement with the line manager prior to implementation. Teleworking can be carried out either by alternating between teleworking and non-teleworking hours (particularly in the case of appointments outside the organisation with clients), or by working full days or half days from home. It is also specified that teleworking days cannot be accumulated or carried over. Under these conditions, days not worked as telework cannot be carried over from one week to the next, even if they coincide with one or more public holidays, unless agreed by management.

ARTICLE 2-3: Occasional teleworking or in exceptional circumstances

Teleworking may be organised on an occasional and temporary basis in exceptional circumstances (prolonged pollution, threat of epidemic or force majeure, strike, etc.) or in specific individual situations (medical reasons, etc.); it being specified that these lists are not exhaustive. Occasional teleworking refers to the employee working from home on an ad hoc basis. All articles of this charter apply to occasional telework, with the exception of Articles 2-2 and 2-3.

ARTICLE 2-3: Voluntary nature

Teleworking is voluntary for employees. Employees are therefore not required to agree to telework or to install their files and work tools at home. However, in exceptional circumstances, such as the threat of an epidemic or in cases of force majeure, the implementation of teleworking may be considered a necessary adjustment to the workplace in order to enable the association to continue its activities and ensure the protection of employees.

In the event that an employee receives a notice from the occupational physician prescribing that all or part of their duties be performed remotely, the transition to remote working will be handled outside the scope of this policy.

ARTICLE 2-4: Procedure for transition to telework

ARTICLE 2-4-1: Transition at the employee's request

The employment contract of an employee who volunteers to telework shall include a clause entitled "telework" referring to the provisions of this charter.

ARTICLE 2-4-2: Transition at the employer's request In the context of specific projects (e.g. maintenance on the premises) or for exceptional organisational reasons, the association may temporarily offer telework to an employee. This request must be sent to the employee in writing by registered email with acknowledgement of receipt at least one clear day before the date on which it is due to take effect. The employee's refusal is not grounds for termination of their employment contract.

ARTICLE 2-4-3: Formalising the transition to telework

The employee and the employer shall formalise their agreement to use telework by any means, specifying the terms and conditions for implementing telework. This may be done by means of an amendment to the employment contract, by email or during the annual appraisal interview. It is specified that the transition to teleworking is effective subject to the prior submission by the employee of a sworn statement: − Declaring that the electrical installations and workspace used by the employee

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are compliant; − Declaring that they have informed their comprehensive home insurance provider of their teleworking activity. Any additional insurance premium costs shall be borne by the teleworker. Failure to provide this certificate will result in teleworking not being permitted.

ARTICLE 3: Place of teleworking

Teleworking is generally carried out at the employee's home (primary or secondary residence, if declared and suitable for professional activities). However, teleworking may be carried out at other locations under the full responsibility of the employee and with the prior agreement of management, provided that: − F r o m a technical standpoint, the employee has access to equipment compatible with teleworking; − The employee ensures that a comfortable teleworking space is set up, equipped with a desk, chair and adequate lighting; − The employee must also check that the co-ownership regulations allow professional activity at home.

For all intents and purposes, it is specified that "grey areas" such as hotels, holiday homes, trains or aeroplanes, if used frequently, remain unauthorised places of work for which the association cannot be held liable in the event of non-compliance by the employee working there with the applicable regulations.

ARTICLE 4: Fitting out and compliance of premises

ARTICLE 4-1: Compliance of premises

In the event of teleworking from home, the employee must provide a workspace that complies with the rules relating to health, safety and working conditions and agrees that a representative of the employer may check the compliance of their home, in particular the electrical installations, prior to the contract taking effect. In the event of a move, the employee undertakes to notify the association and provide it with their new address. The employee must then send a new certificate as referred to in Article 2-4-3 of this charter within 48 hours. If the new accommodation is found to be non-compliant, teleworking may be terminated under the conditions set out in the article entitled "Reversibility of teleworking".

ARTICLE 4-2: Disabled workers

Disabled workers who wish to work from home will be able to benefit from appropriate measures to facilitate access to teleworking, such as adaptation of furniture, installation of special software, and adaptation of the working environment.

ARTICLE 5: Organisation of working time

During periods of teleworking, the time worked will be counted as actual working time on the same basis as would have been used if the employee had worked on the association's premises. Employees are free to organise their working time as they wish, subject to the limits imposed by the legislation in force concerning working hours and the right to disconnect as provided for in the association's guide to the proper use of digital technology. Employees shall expressly ensure that they remain technically available (by mobile phone, email and the collaborative application in use within the association) during normal working hours. Employees must enter their telework days in their shared electronic calendar (currently Outlook) in advance, as soon as they know the dates. Overtime may only be worked in exceptional circumstances and at the express request of the association.

ARTICLE 6: Working hours and workload

ARTICLE 6-1: Monitoring of working time

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Employees shall record their working hours for each day worked using the PSNext software, indicating the time spent on different tasks or projects. The aforementioned PSNext software will enable detailed monitoring of employee activity.

ARTICLE 6-2: Workload regulation procedures

Teleworking must not result in an increase in the employee's usual workload or compromise the proper performance of their work. The employee shall communicate with their line manager on the progress of their work. On this occasion, the employee's workload may be adjusted if necessary. The employee must also contact their line manager without delay in the event of any difficulty in carrying out the work entrusted to them, in order to find a solution as quickly as possible. Regardless of any adjustments made during the year, the employee's workload will be discussed during the annual review provided for in the "Annual review" section of this policy.

ARTICLE 7: Work equipment

The association provides and maintains the equipment necessary for the employee's work. Equipment provided for professional use only includes: − Small office supplies (pencils, reams of paper, etc.); − Remote network access; − A laptop; − Earphones or a headset for conference calls and video calls, if necessary. In the event of the termination of teleworking or the termination of your employment contract for any reason whatsoever, you must return all equipment entrusted to you.

ARTICLE 7-1: Maintenance of equipment

The employee undertakes: − To take care of the equipment entrusted to them; − To immediately notify the association in the event of a breakdown or malfunction of work equipment.

ARTICLE 7-2: Intervention on equipment

The association provides technical support during both the installation and use of the systems made available. If a technician needs to work on the equipment, the employee agrees to allow access to their workspace. The employee must be notified in advance of the technician's visit.

ARTICLE 7-3: Use of equipment

The employee undertakes to read the instructions for use of the equipment provided to them and to comply with them strictly, failing which they may be subject to penalties including dismissal. The employee also undertakes to complete, prior to teleworking, the necessary training on the installation, use and maintenance of this equipment and, during the teleworking period, if necessary, any training related to its adaptation. Finally, the employee undertakes, under penalty of sanctions that may include dismissal, not to use the equipment made available to them by the association for any purpose other than professional use. Finally, the employee undertakes to take the necessary measures to protect the supplies made available to them against any risk of damage, theft or use by third parties, communication of information it contains. If, despite the precautions taken, a malicious act is committed at the teleworking location, the employee must immediately report it to the police and provide a copy of the report to the association.

ARTICLE 7-4: Coverage of expenses

The association undertakes to cover the costs of maintenance, repair and, where necessary, replacement of equipment. However, it is specified that, insofar as teleworking is a voluntary arrangement, the employee shall not be entitled to any compensation for working from home. As the use of a personal internet connection does not incur any costs for the employee, it is not, therefore,

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subject to any reimbursement by the association. Similarly, no other expenses shall be covered, of any kind whatsoever (electricity, heating, etc.), as the nature of the activity carried out is not, by its very nature, likely to incur expenses.

ARTICLE 7-5:

Return All equipment provided by the association remains its property and as such is unseizable. The employee undertakes to return the equipment provided by the association at the end of the teleworking period without delay at the association's request.

ARTICLE 8: Insurance If the employee uses their home to telework, they undertake to inform their insurer that they are working at home with equipment belonging to the association.

ARTICLE 9: Data protection

The employee undertakes to comply with the association's IT charter and the rules established by the association to ensure data protection and confidentiality.

The employee undertakes to take all necessary precautions to ensure and guarantee the confidentiality of work, documents and IT systems. In the event of difficulties or if they notice any anomalies, they must immediately inform their line manager. Employees shall take particular care not to disclose any information to third parties and to lock their remote connection to ensure that they are the only users (except, of course, the association's management).

ARTICLE 10: Integration into the working community

Even on days when they are working remotely, teleworkers are still required to come to the association's premises to attend face-to-face work meetings for the smooth running of the service.

ARTICLE 11: Annual review

The employee is entitled to an annual interview during which the conditions of employment and the workload associated with teleworking will be discussed.

ARTICLE 12: Protection of privacy

If a means of surveillance is put in place (technical monitoring, a system designed to combat cybercrime, etc.), the employee must be informed. This system must relate exclusively to the use of the tools made available for professional purposes.

ARTICLE 13: Training and individual rights

Apart from specific training related to the use of the technical equipment made available to them, employees working remotely enjoy the same individual rights as other employees of the association, particularly in terms of professional training, career development, professional interviews and evaluation policy; remote working must not constitute an obstacle to the employee's career development. Employees shall therefore be placed in the same position as employees performing comparable work on the association's premises, particularly with regard to workload and deadlines.

ARTICLE 14: Collective rights

Employees shall enjoy the same collective legal and contractual rights as those applicable to employees in comparable situations working on the association's premises, particularly with regard to access to trade union information and professional elections.

ARTICLE 15: Health and safety

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Employees shall be informed of the applicable health and safety rules.

In the event of illness or accident during teleworking days, employees undertake to notify their line manager without delay.

ARTICLE 16: Adaptation period and reversibility of telework

ARTICLE 16-1: Adaptation period

The new work arrangement is subject to a one-month adjustment period during which either party may freely terminate telework, provided that five working days' notice is given. If telework is terminated, the employee shall then be offered a position at the association's premises corresponding to their qualifications.

ARTICLE 16-2: Reversibility of telework

Beyond the adjustment period referred to in the above article, teleworking may be terminated under the following conditions:

ARTICLE 16-2-1: At the request of the employee

The employee's request is not necessary, as access to the offices remains unrestricted.

ARTICLE 16-2-2: At the employer's request

The association may ask an employee working remotely to return to work at the association's premises. This request must be justified and sent to the employee in writing by registered email with acknowledgement of receipt at least one month before the date on which it is due to take effect. The employee will have five working days to respond in writing to the employer's request. If the employee agrees, they will have priority for a position at the association's premises that matches their qualifications and professional skills.

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Annex II

Article 8 of the employment contract- Telework

In accordance with your request, and except in exceptional circumstances, you will be able to telework up to an average of two days per week, in agreement with your manager and in accordance with the provisions of:

- The charter in force within the association on telework and the related memorandum;
- The IT charter applicable to the association.

You certify that you have read and understood these provisions and undertake to comply strictly with them.

The association provides the following equipment for exclusively professional use:

- Small office supplies (pencils, reams of paper, etc.);
- Remote network access;
- A laptop computer.

However, it is specified that since teleworking has been requested by you for personal convenience, you will not be entitled to any occupancy allowance for your work at home.

As the use of your personal internet connection does not incur any costs for you, it is not, therefore, subject to any reimbursement by the association. Similarly, no other expenses will be covered (electricity, heating, etc.), as the nature of the activity carried out is not, by its nature, likely to incur expenses.

Finally, we ask that you exercise your right to disconnect outside of your working hours in order to guarantee your right to health, safety, rest and a good work-life balance.

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